RABBENU AVRAHAM BEN HARAMBAM

Why a Meal Before the Blessing? Yishak, Esav and Yaakov

Rabbenu Avraham on Parashat Toledot

Series: Rabbenu Avraham ben HaRambam on the Parashah: ideas from Rabbenu Avraham's commentary on the Torah (which survives on Bereshit and Shemot), taught each week at the Monday HaMaspik LeOvdei HaShem shiur.

Source: The whole HaMaspik shiur of the week of Toledot 5787 (HaMaspik 10.4): Rabbenu Avraham's discussion of the blessings, from his chapter on perishut.

Topic: Why Yishak asked for a meal before blessing, and why the blessings are physical.

Part One — The Story (Bereshit 27)

The Rabbi first read the verses, asking us to notice a few details.

Yishak to Esav: *הנה נא זקנתי לא ידעתי יום מותי.* "I have grown old; I don't know the day of my death." Take your gear and hunt for me.

ועשה לי מטעמים כאשר אהבתי והביאה לי ואכלה בעבור תברכך נפשי בטרם אמות.

"Make me tasty food as I love, and I will eat, **so that my soul may bless you** before I die."

Rivkah repeats it to Yaakov: *הביאה לי ציד ועשה לי מטעמים ואכלה ואברכה לפני ה' לפני מותי.* She says **"and I will bless you."** She does not say "my soul."

Yaakov to Yishak: בעבור תברכני נפשך *קום נא שבה ואכלה מצידי*. "So that **your soul** may bless me."

Yaakov brings wine: *ויבא לו יין וישת.* Yishak never asked for wine.

The blessing: *ויתן לך האלקים מטל השמים ומשמני הארץ ורב דגן ותירש. יעבדוך עמים... הוה גביר לאחיך... ארריך ארור ומברכיך ברוך.* First produce, then power, then "those who bless you are blessed."

Yishak to Esav afterwards: *הן גביר שמתיו לך... ודגן ותירש סמכתיו.* Now he puts **the mastery first** and the produce second.

Part Two — The Two Questions

עוד אחד מן הקושיות החזקות כנגד הפרישות. One of the strong questions against perishut is the story of Yishak's blessing. It comes from two sides.

Question 1: the meal. Yishak ties his blessing to tasty food, and Yaakov adds wine. *איזו חיבה להנאת העולם גדולה מחיבה זו?* What greater attachment to worldly pleasure could there be?

Question 2: the blessing. The blessing itself is entirely physical: dew, fat of the land, grain, wine, nations bowing. *כל הדברים האלו בעלי טבע גשמי הם.*

Part Three — The Meal Was Food for the Soul

Three preliminaries

1. The soul depends on the body

Our real identity is the soul, our mind and intellect. That is **נשמת האדם היא הקשר בינו ובין בוראו.** where the prophet receives prophecy.

But as long as a person is alive, the soul is **entangled with the body**. *ובהחלש הגוף תחלשנה מחשבותיו.* When the body weakens, so do the thoughts.

"We feel this. When you're ill, it's hard to think. It's hard to develop spiritually."

2. Prophecy needs joy and strength

אין הנבואה שורה לא מתוך עצבות ולא מתוך עצלות אלא מתוך שמחה.

You cannot prophesy when you are sad, lethargic or ill. You need to be awake, full of energy and hope. So the prophets kept instruments by them, *נבל ותוף וחליל וכינור*. Elisha asked for a musician: *ועתה קחו לי מנגן*.

"This is why we have a duty to look after our bodies, to exercise and look after our health. When your body is strong, you can develop yourself spiritually much better."

Rabbenu Avraham notes that his father wrote this in three places: the **Eight Chapters** (ch. 7), the **Mishneh Torah** (Yesodei HaTorah), and the **Moreh**. We have learned the first two together.

3. Yishak was weak, and this was a prophetic blessing

On the simple level, the dim eyes explain how Yaakov could take the blessing. On a deeper level, says Rabbenu Avraham, **the eyes show the state of the whole body**. If his sight had weakened, so had the rest of him. *ויהי כי זקן יצחק ותכהין עיניו מראות.*

Yishak did not want an ordinary blessing, *כדרך שמברכים בני אדם איש את רעהו*. He wanted to bless **מתוך שפע נבואי**, from prophetic inspiration. Even Bilam could only say *את אשר ישים ה' בפי*; all the more so Yishak.

How do we know it was prophetic? When Yishak discovered what had happened, *ויחרד יצחק חרדה גדלה עד מאד*. Yet he did not retract. He said: **גם ברוך יהיה**.

"If your child deceived you and took the wrong thing, you'd say: I take it back. He didn't." Yishak knew the blessing came from Hashem. If it reached Yaakov, Yaakov was meant to have it.

The answer

Yishak did not ask for the meal **לספק תאותו**, to satisfy a craving, nor as a bribe for the blessing. He asked for it **להשיב את מזגו ולשמח נפשו**: to restore his strength and gladden his soul, so that he could bless prophetically.

That is why he said **בעבור תברכך נפשי**, "so that **my soul** may bless you."

Rabbenu Avraham adds, as his own suggestion, that Yishak may have felt a sudden decline. He says twice, *לא ידעתי יום מותי* and *בטרם אמות*. *"It happens with the elderly: a ninety-year-old goes into hospital and a week later he's gone."*

Part Four — Who Understood "My Soul"?

The verses show three different people hearing the same instruction.

	What they heard	What they understood
Rivkah	Heard Yishak say *תברכך נפשי*	Repeated only *ואברככה*. She did not stress the prophetic point
Esav	Heard it from Yishak directly	Understood it once he heard it, and said *בעבור תברכני נפשך*
Yaakov	Never heard it. Rivkah left it out	**Worked it out himself**, and said *בעבור תברכני נפשך*

Yaakov's insight: why would my father ask for game and tasty food now? He must be preparing for a prophetic blessing. So Yaakov said "**your soul**", and on his own initiative **brought wine**. *ויין ישמח לבב אנוש* (fitting for Rosh Hodesh).

Not to drunkenness: *אל תחשוב שהוא חס ושלום שתה משקה משכחת השכל.* Just enough to lift the spirit. *"The difference between one shot of whiskey and five."*

About Rivkah: Rabbenu Avraham is careful. He does not mean she missed the importance of the blessing, only that she did not dwell on the exact wording. Possibly she just shortened it. *"Not every prophet understands everything all the time."*

A side point: Esav was not simply wicked

כי אף שלא הגיע למעלת שלמותו של יעקב, היתה לו גם כן שלמות.

Rabbenu Avraham says plainly that **Esav had a real level of perfection**, though less than Yaakov's. The proofs: Yishak thought him worthy of the prophetic blessing, and Esav longed for the blessing and grieved when he lost it.

The Rabbi recalled **Rabbi Jacobs z"l** of Neve Shalom in Wembley, the scholar of Midrash, who explained this to him many times. **Midrash teaches in black and white.** To educate clearly, especially beginners and children, it contrasts the very righteous with the less righteous. So children come home with *Yaakov HaTzaddik* and *Esav HaRasha*.

"We need to get out of this idea that Esav was this wicked person."

Why ask Esav to fetch it?

Why not prepare the food himself, or ask Rivkah? Two answers:

1. **Rabbi Avraham HeHasid** (a friend of the author): to create a closeness between Yishak and the son he was about to bless.
2. **Rabbenu Avraham:** fresh game simply suited Yishak better and would revive him more.

Part Five — Why the Blessings Are Physical

Material blessing is the means

Rabbenu Avraham returns to his father's teaching in **Hilchot Teshuvah**: the Torah's material rewards are there so that a person is **free** to serve Hashem and grow, not as the reward itself.

So read the blessing in order:

Step	The words	What it means
1. The means	*מטל השמים ומשמני הארץ ורב דגן ותירש*	Plenty, so you are free from worry
2. The result	*יעבדוך עמים... הוה גביר לאחיך*	You grow until you stand out spiritually, and people look up to you
3. The Shekhinah	*ארריך ארור ומברכיך ברוך*	The Shekhinah rests on you, so whoever is with you is blessed

"You've always read these blessings wrong. Not: you'll have money, so people will bow to you because of your power. You'll have parnassah, so you'll be free to work on yourself, and people will see you're on a different level."

Compare Ki Tavo: **וראו כל עמי הארץ כי שם ה' נקרא עליך ויראו ממך.**

The same blessing as Bilam's

Bilam's final blessing came with *ותהי עליו רוח אלקים*.

מה טבו אהליך יעקב משכנתיך ישראל.

אהליך יעקב — (*sniut*) your physical homes, set so no one looked into another's.

משכנתיך ישראל — Bilam is addressing **Hashem**: *Your* dwelling places among Israel, the Mishkan and the Mikdash. *ושכנתי בתוכם*.

A few verses later Bilam says **מברכיך ברוך וארריך ארור**. Because the Shekhinah dwells among Israel, those who bless them are blessed.

Yishak said the same thing, briefly. *ברכת יצחק נאמרה בקיצור, ברכת בלעם בהרחבה.*

What about the Midrash on the order?

Yishak puts the blessing first; Bilam puts the curse first. A well-known derash says each showed what he really wanted.

Rabbenu Avraham says not to be troubled. Such derashot are meant **for the general public**. On the plain level it is the same blessing, and the order makes no difference.

The blessing is that you can keep the misvot

Yishak spelled out the physical goods, just as the Torah spells out the physical rewards, and **hinted** at the spiritual ones.

את הברכה אשר תשמעו אל מצות ה' אלקיכם. (Reeh)

"I've read this verse so many times and never noticed." The blessing **is** that you listen to Hashem's misvot. That is the greatest blessing. And how can you do it? When you have what you need.

The proof: הן גביר שמתיו לך

When Yishak tells Esav what he gave Yaakov, he reverses the order:

הן גביר שמתיו לך... ודגן ותירש סמכתיו.

The **main** blessing was the greatness, so he says it first. The produce is only *סמכתיו*, "I supported him": a means and a help, **not the goal**.

Esav's blessing

Esav was blessed **only with this world**: *הנה משמני הארץ יהיה מושבך... ועל חרבך תחיה ואת אחיך תעבד.*

Will he always serve? Only while Yaakov's descendants keep the Torah. Onkelos: *כד יעברון בנוהי על פתגמי אורייתא*. When they stray from it, Esav's fear of them leaves him, though even then he does not reach Yaakov's greatness.

Summary

Question 1: why did Yishak ask for a meal? He was old and weak, his eyes were dim, and he may have felt death near. Prophecy needs a strong body and joy. The meal, and Yaakov's wine, were to revive him for a **prophetic blessing**: *בעבור תברכך נפשי*.

Who understood: Yaakov worked it out alone. Esav understood once he heard it. Rivkah did not pass it on. Esav had real *shleimut*, less than Yaakov's.

Question 2: why are the blessings physical? Material plenty frees a person to grow. That growth makes him distinguished, the Shekhinah rests on him, and so *מברכיך ברוך*, as in Bilam's blessing. The proof is *הן גביר שמתיו לך... ודגן ותירש סמכתיו*: greatness is the goal, the produce only the support.

"Plenty to share on the Shabbos table this week. Listen to it again before Shabbos."

Coming Up

Next week: back to perishut. Fasting as training, the apparent contradiction with the Rambam in the Eight Chapters, the obstacles, the signs, and the benefits.

Tomorrow evening: the Moreh Nevuchim shiur continues as usual.

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